James Chang

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A career of product instinct. Shipping now at AI speed.

About

Fifteen years sourcing products across Asia and the US taught me what real importers need. A decade in product management at Gannett/LocaliQ, Sunrise, MEDL, and earlier roles taught me how to ship.

Now I combine both — founding Aleph Co. to build compliance tooling for the sourcers I used to be, while shipping six other products in parallel because the operator problems I know best aren't confined to one market.

MBA from USC Marshall (2012), CSPO, and a lifetime food blog at The Thirsty Pig. Based in Los Angeles.

Current projects

Seven products in production across compliance SaaS, AI experiments, marketplaces, native mobile, and long-form publishing.

Aleph Compliance

Product compliance for US importers. FDA FSVP, CPSIA/CPC, California Prop 65, multi-state PFAS — one platform.

TableDrop

Restaurant reservation marketplace. Sellers list hard-to-get tables, buyers purchase them. Next.js + Stripe + Playwright.

The Judge Tool

Digital KCBS BBQ competition judging. Real-time tabulation, audit trails, 16,424 LOC + 113 tests shipped in 20 days.

The Thirsty Pig

Food and travel blog since 2007. 2026 rebuild: 923 posts recovered from the Wayback Machine, 1,649 Instagram posts archived, 2,900+ pages.

Bahtzang Trader

AI trading-decision experiment using Claude Sonnet. Paper-trading sandbox — not a live trading service.

The Fantastic Leagues

Fantasy baseball with league-context AI. 26 feature modules, 730 tests, 8 AI features (Gemini + Claude), live auction WebSockets.

Tastemakers

iOS restaurant-review app. Cross-platform build — iOS, Android, web. Currently paused.

Selected case studies

ALEPH COMPLIANCE · 2025–PRESENT · FOUNDER

Founding a SaaS for the sourcer I used to be.

I spent fifteen years sourcing products across Asia and the US — at YETI, at Cheng Loong in Shanghai, at AT&T Wireless, at independent sourcing firms. The through-line across every one of those roles was the same: regulatory compliance was a disaster, and everyone pretended it wasn't.

In the last three years, FDA FSVP enforcement got real. CPSIA penalties for children's products stopped being theoretical. California Prop 65 letters became a cottage industry. Multi-state PFAS laws arrived with different deadlines in each jurisdiction. Importers were hit with $100K+ penalties for documentation failures that were genuinely invisible under the workflows most companies had.

The software landscape had two bad options: legal-services firms selling hour-based consulting (slow, not scalable), or generic compliance SaaS built for public companies (overkill, expensive, nothing to do with how an importer actually operates). There was a gap for product-shaped software built from the importer's real workflow.

I started Aleph Co. and shipped Aleph Compliance for that gap. The judgment was sequencing: build FSVP first because it's the most technical and has the sharpest enforcement gradient; add CPSIA/CPC next because children's-product importers are the most pain-aware buyers; Prop 65 and PFAS on top, because once the audit framework exists, each new regulation is an incremental module rather than a rebuild.

What I'd do differently. I originally shipped under the name "FSVP Pro" — accurate for v1, but too narrow. Rebranding to Aleph Co. mid-build cost weeks I didn't need to spend. I should have named it for the shape of the platform, not the shape of the first module.

GANNETT / USA TODAY NETWORK (LOCALIQ) · 2022–2024 · SENIOR PM

Scheduling, 0 → 4,900 users in year one.

LocaliQ (Gannett's SMB marketing arm inside the USA Today Network) had a portfolio of point solutions for small businesses — websites, SEO, ads, social — but no scheduling. Our customers were losing appointments to competitors who had a booking tool.

I owned Scheduling from conception to deployment as a Senior PM: product strategy, roadmap, the full cross-functional team.

The biggest judgment call was what to build first. The engineering team wanted to ship AI-driven scheduling rules and advanced routing; internal stakeholders wanted feature parity with Calendly. I argued for neither: SMB customers had an integration problem, not a sophistication problem. Calendar sync (Google + Outlook) and SMS notifications were the two things they couldn't live without, and the two things most competitors' free tiers hid behind a paywall. We shipped those first and held everything else.

4,900 free accounts and **400+ paid** in year one — against an internal plan that projected meaningfully smaller numbers. I also picked up product ownership of LocaliQ's SEO offerings and its GenAI tooling in the same window.

What I'd do differently. I introduced AI features too late. By Q4 of year one, prospects evaluating competing tools were asking about GenAI scheduling rules and assistant handoff — we'd deprioritized it correctly for v1 but kept deprioritizing it after we shouldn't have. I'd start that track sooner in v2.

THE THIRSTY PIG · 2026 REBUILD · SOLO

Rebuilding 17 years of blog from the Wayback Machine.

The Thirsty Pig is my food and travel blog. I launched it in 2007 on Blogger, moved to WordPress twice, and ran it across three domains (`thirstypig.com`, `thethirstypig.com`, `blog.thethirstypig.com`) for fifteen years before all three went dark when a hosting migration went sideways. Seventeen years of writing, thousands of posts, mostly offline. 1,649 Instagram posts sat in a data export nobody could search.

I rebuilt the whole thing in early 2026 as a Python + Astro project. The scraper side pulled **923 unique blog posts** from the Wayback Machine across three domains — deduplicating 228 exact + 10 fuzzy matches — and recovered images at wildly different rates per platform (Blogspot: ~98% thanks to Google's CDN; legacy WordPress uploads: ~45%; recent `wp.com`-hosted images: ~1%, because Photon wasn't archived). The Instagram side imported the full JSON export, recovered posts with epoch-0 timestamps via media-level metadata, and preserved captions, hashtags, and GPS. I geocoded **1,000+ addresses** via the Foursquare Places API.

The output is **2,900+ pages** — posts, categories, search, maps, and best-of — rendered through Astro with Tina CMS for Git-backed editing. 7,500+ images and 213 videos, all self-hosted.

What I'd do differently. I started with the Wayback scrape. The Instagram import would have delivered 60% of the user-facing value in 30% of the total work. I'd flip the order.

Experience

Aleph Co. — Founder & Operator

2025 – Present · Los Angeles, CA

- Founded and operate Aleph Compliance, a SaaS platform for US importers covering FDA FSVP, CPSIA/CPC, California Prop 65, and multi-state PFAS regulations.
- Shipping six additional products in parallel — Bahtzang Trader (AI trading-decision experiment), TableDrop (reservation marketplace), The Fantastic Leagues (fantasy baseball with league-context AI), The Judge Tool (KCBS BBQ judging), KTV Singer (multi-platform karaoke), and The Thirsty Pig rebuild.
- Project deep-dives: /work/.

Gannett / LocaliQ / USA Today Network — Senior Product Manager

2022 – 2024 · Woodland Hills, CA

- Shipped Scheduling product 0→1 in year one: 4,900 free accounts + 400 paid, driven by prioritizing calendar sync and SMS notifications ahead of AI features.
- Owned product for LocaliQ's SEO offerings and its GenAI tooling portfolio for SMB customers.
- **Byline:** Appointment Scheduling Simplified: Introducing Our (Free) Scheduling Software · LocaliQ Blog · Feb 2023
- **Press:** LocaliQ Launches New Scheduling Management Software for Small Businesses · Gannett / USA Today press release · Dec 2022

Sunrise Integration — Project Manager

2020 · Los Angeles, CA

- Led development team for the WarehouseConnector SaaS platform launch.
- Managed client delivery on Jira across multiple ecommerce integrations, including TeeLaunch and SAFIOsolutions.

Movley — Operations & Product Manager (now Ops Ninja)

2019 · Los Angeles, CA (Remote)

- Product-managed the website, client portal, and inspector portal.
- Managed overseas teams across India, the Philippines, and China. Built budgets and operating policy.

MEDL Mobile — Product / Project Manager

May 2018 – Dec 2018 · Irvine, CA

- Managed creative and software projects for mobile and web applications. Vetted ecommerce and signature-API vendors.

Education

USC Marshall School of Business

Master of Business Administration (MBA), 2012. Class President.

Certifications

- Certified Scrum Product Owner (CSPO), Scrum Alliance · 2019
- Product Management Certificate, Product School · 2018
- Data-Driven Product Management, LinkedIn Learning · 2024
- Product Management: Building a Product Roadmap, LinkedIn Learning · 2024
- Technology for Product Managers, LinkedIn Learning · 2024
- Toggl Hire Product Development · 2024
- Appcues Basics · 2023
- Jasper Certified · 2023
- HubSpot Inbound Certification · 2019
- Google Analytics for Beginners · 2018

Skills

Product	0→1 development, roadmapping, discovery & user research, A/B testing, GenAI integration, native-mobile PM
Tools	Jira, Linear, Figma, Notion, Prisma, Supabase, Stripe, Claude API, GitHub, Vercel, Railway
Engineering (hands-on)	TypeScript, Python, Next.js, Astro, Tailwind, FastAPI, Socket.IO, Prisma · **AI-assisted development** (Claude Code, MCP, agent workflows)
Domains	B2B SaaS, regulatory compliance, fantasy sports, food & dining, global supply chain & sourcing
Languages	English (native), Mandarin (fluent), Taiwanese (fluent)

Memberships & leadership

Chinese American Museum Board Member

Feb 2026 – Present · Los Angeles, CA

Serving on the board of the Chinese American Museum in downtown Los Angeles, the first museum in the United States dedicated to the history and ongoing story of Chinese Americans.

James Chang · Los Angeles, CA

reveal email · LinkedIn (https://www.linkedin.com/in/jimmychang316) · GitHub (https://github.com/thirstypig) · Résumé (PDF)

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